



Ghanaian
Independence
Day stamps

Independence

After World War II, many Africans wanted to end colonial rule, and govern their own countries.

Colonial powers such as France, Portugal, and Britain fought to prevent this, and there were bloody wars of independence in Algeria, Mozambique, Angola, and Zimbabwe. By the late 1960s most African countries had gained independence, but political and economic problems remained.



Returning refugees, Angola

Gold Coast

One of the first colonies to become independent was the former British colony of the Gold Coast. After World War II, anti-colonial feeling had intensified, and, in 1957, the state of Ghana (which was named after a powerful West African medieval empire) became independent. A leading nationalist, Kwame Nkrumah (1909–72) became the new country's first prime minister. In 1960, Nkrumah declared Ghana a republic and himself president for life. He became increasingly dictatorial, while drawing ever further away from the west. In 1966, a police-military coup overthrew Nkrumah.



OAU
summit, Tunisia

OAU member
states now
number 50.

Organization of African Unity

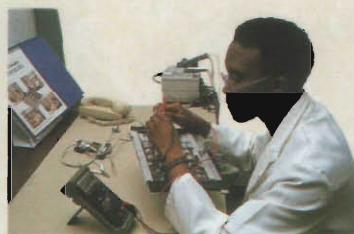
In 1963, the heads of 30 independent African states met to form the OAU (Organization of African Unity). Its aim was to promote political and economic co-operation between the states, and help colonies achieve independence.



A taxi stand for whites, South Africa, 1967

Apartheid

By the 1980s, only South Africa was still trying to retain white-minority power. The white government had passed the Apartheid (separateness) Policy in 1948, which classified people according to race. Under apartheid, those classified as Black, Coloured, or Asian had few rights. Apartheid was abolished in 1994.



Electronics technician



Game park, Kenya

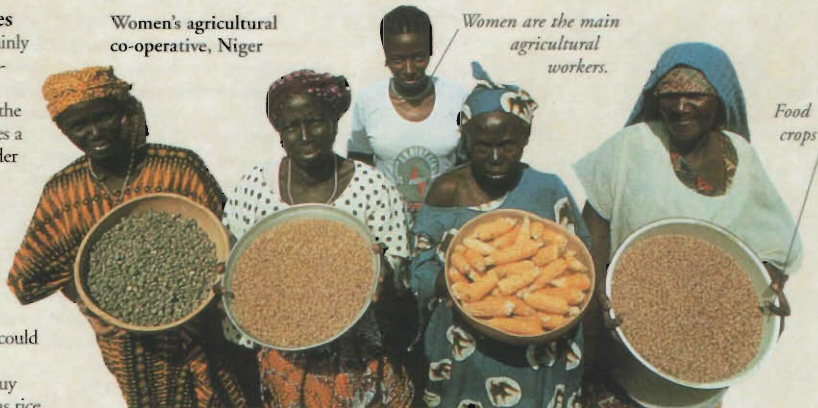
Modern Africa

Mineral-rich Africa has a thriving mining industry. More recently, new African electronics plants are specializing in the assembly of imported electronic components.

Village co-operatives

Agricultural workers (mainly women) set up village co-operatives to grow food crops, which they sell at the local market. This reverses a situation that existed under colonial governments, when small-scale farmers were forced to grow cash crops (coffee, groundnuts, cocoa, and cotton) to sell to large European companies. The farmers could not grow food crops for themselves, and had to buy expensive imports, such as rice.

Women's agricultural
co-operative, Niger



Women are the main
agricultural
workers.

Food
crops



Deforestation, Somalia

Environmental devastation

In semi-arid areas of Africa, such as Somalia, land is gradually turning into desert. Since the 1950s, there has been a fall in the average annual rainfall, and much of the land has become very dry. The people have often over-used the land for cash crops, and cut down the trees for firewood.

Ken Saro-Wiwa

Ken Saro-Wiwa (1941–1995), a human rights campaigner, was hanged along with eight others by Nigeria's military government. His "crime" was to speak out against the pollution of tribal lands by government-backed international oil companies.

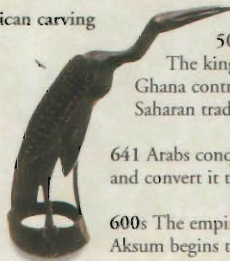
Timeline

2500 BC Climatic changes in the Sahara region force people to move southward.

c.600 BC Kushite people of Sudan expand and base their capital at Meroë.

c.AD 320–25 King Ezana of Aksum becomes Christian.

African carving



500–1300
The kingdom of
Ghana controls trans-
Saharan trade.

641 Arabs conquer Egypt,
and convert it to Islam.

600s The empire based at
Aksum begins to decline.

1497 Portuguese explorers
land on east coast, after
sailing around Africa.

1900 Most of the Sahara
region comes under French
colonial rule.

1940 Italian forces invade
North Africa; Germans
follow one year later.

1945 League of Arab States
is founded; it includes eight
African nations.

1973–75 Horn of Africa
suffers a severe drought.

1994–95 In Rwanda
800,000 Hutus are
massacred by Tutsis;
millions flee the country.

FIND OUT
MORE

BENIN
EMPIRE

GREAT
ZIMBABWE

MALI
EMPIRE

MANDELA,
NELSON

RELIGIONS

SLAVERY

SONGHA
EMPIRE

SOUTH AFRICA,
HISTORY OF